food’. They ‘sing and dance and afford the merriest sport in the world’, leaping, tumbling, raising their legs to their necks and pirouetting to delight the deities. After the ‘spirit of the idols has eaten the substance of the food’, they ‘eat together with great mirth and jollity’. Pleasantly disposed by the evening showbiz, the gods and goddesses descend from the temple walls at night and ‘consort’ with each other—or so the priest announces the next morning—bringing great joy and relief to all. ‘The flesh of these maidens,’ Marco adds salaciously, ‘is so hard that no one could grasp or pinch them in any place . . . their breasts do not hang down, but remain upstanding and erect.’ For a penny, however, ‘they will allow a man to pinch [their bodies] as hard as he can’. Marco doesn’t say how common this custom was, or whether he himself partook in it.

Dark skin is preferred by the people. ‘When a child is born they anoint him once a week with oil of sesame, and this makes him grow much darker [for] I assure you that the darkest man here is the most highly esteemed and considered better than the others who are not so dark.’ No wonder their gods are all black ‘and their devils white as snow’. This detail is interesting though sesame oil, while beneficial for the skin, doesn’t really darken it; perhaps Marco confused it with another oil. It is also worth noting that a higher value for lighter skin—correlated with the higher varnas and castes that emerged after the Indo-Aryan migration—doesn’t seem to have penetrated folk culture this far south. But cultural standards have long since changed, as evidenced by all the ‘Fair & Lovely’ fairness cream ads in the same regions today.

A group of their holy men, the yogis, eat frugally and live longer than most, some as long as 200 years, claims Marco. In one religious order, men even go stark naked and ‘lead a harsh and austere life’. These men believe that all living beings have a soul and take pains to avoid hurting even the tiniest creatures. They take their food over large dried leaves. When asked why they do not cover their private parts, they say, ‘We go naked because we want nothing of this world. For we came into this world naked and unclothed . . . It is because you employ this member in sin and lechery that you cover it and are ashamed of it. But we are no more ashamed of it than of our fingers.’ Among them, only those who can conquer sexual desire become monks. ‘So strict are these idolaters and so stubborn in their misbelief,’ opines Marco.